ORPHENADRINE

Anticholinergic
Short-term use

CHEMICAL NAME N,N-dimethyl-2-[(2-methylphenyl)(phenyl)methoxy]ethanamine (as citrate or hydrochloride)

CLASS Centrally acting skeletal muscle relaxant with anticholinergic action

TRADE NAMES Norflex · Norgesic (with paracetamol) · Myogesic

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Acute painful musculoskeletal conditions: back pain, muscle spasm, sprains (adjunct to rest and physiotherapy).
- Drug-induced parkinsonism (hydrochloride form).

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Acts in brainstem to reduce muscle spasm (exact mechanism unclear).
- Anticholinergic (antimuscarinic) and weak antihistamine effects.
- Mild analgesic effect.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO:** extended-release tablets swallowed whole, or combination tablets.
- **IM/IV** injection (60 mg) in some markets — IV slowly over 5 min.
- Usually limited to 2–3 weeks.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Dry mouth, blurred vision, constipation.
- Drowsiness, dizziness, light-headedness.
- Urinary hesitancy.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Urinary retention.
- Tachycardia, palpitations.
- Confusion and hallucinations in elderly.
- Anaphylaxis (rare).

DOSAGES

- **Adult PO:** 100 mg twice daily (ER).
- **Norgesic-type combination:** 1–2 tablets 3 times daily (count paracetamol content).
- **IM/IV:** 60 mg, may repeat every 12 h.
- Elderly: lower doses.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Glaucoma (angle-closure).
- Prostatic hypertrophy, bladder-neck obstruction.
- Myasthenia gravis; peptic ulcer with obstruction.
- **Caution:** heart disease, arrhythmias, elderly.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Other anticholinergics** (TCAs, antihistamines): additive effects.
- **Alcohol, CNS depressants:** ↑ sedation.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 1 h. **Duration:** 12 h (ER).
- Metabolised extensively in liver.
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 14–16 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Ask about glaucoma and urinary problems.
- Monitor urine output and bowel habit.
- Assess spasm, pain and mobility.
- Fall precautions, especially in elderly.
- Check total paracetamol if combination product used.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- May cause drowsiness and blurred vision — avoid driving.
- Sip water or chew sugar-free gum for dry mouth.
- Avoid alcohol.
- Report difficulty passing urine or eye pain.

KEY POINTS

- Central muscle relaxant with anticholinergic effects.
- Short-term use with rest and physiotherapy.
- Avoid in glaucoma and BPH.
- Often combined with paracetamol.